

By **JYOTI DESHPANDE**

THE GOLDEN AGE FOR INDIAN STORYTELLING

AS THE INDIAN ENTERTAINMENT INDUSTRY EVOLVES, TECHNOLOGICAL ADVANCEMENTS, GLOBAL PARTNERSHIPS AND HYPER-LOCAL CONTENT ARE CREATING NEW OPPORTUNITIES AND CONNECTING DIVERSE NARRATIVES TO AUDIENCES WORLDWIDE

Over the past decade, the Indian entertainment industry has showcased remarkable resilience and an extraordinary ability to adapt. From my vantage point at Jio Studios, I have witnessed first-hand how rapidly evolving technologies, shifting audience behaviours and bold storytelling are reshaping how we create, deliver and consume content. The year ahead holds the promise of more significant opportunities—and challenges—as we collectively navigate a dynamic and evolving landscape that is witnessing a fascinating interplay of scale and intimacy.

On the one hand, the bigger theatrical releases promise the revival of the film business in India. On the other hand, smaller, more independent films like *Laapataa Ladies* and *All We Imagine as Light* find audiences through a combination of film festivals, overseas markets, streaming and specifically curated theatrical releases. Balancing these forces will be the key to unlocking the full potential of our industry.

Even as streaming continues to flourish, the magic of the big screen remains irreplaceable. India's enduring love affair with cinema halls is evident. While audiences flock to theatres to share the joy of a blockbuster, they also cherish the intimacy of binge-watching a gripping series at home. We successfully brought audiences to theatres in hordes for films like *Stree 2*, *Shaitaan*, *Article 370* and *Singham Again*. Notably, the streaming success of *Laapataa Ladies* extended its theatrical run by six weeks. This duality highlights the strength of our entertainment landscape and the versatility of Indian audiences.

Again, on the one hand, large-scale mergers and acquisitions, such as

THE RESURGENCE OF BIG-TICKET **THEATRICAL RELEASES IS ENCOURAGING, BUT SUSTAINING THIS MOMENTUM** WILL REQUIRE A RENEWED FOCUS ON CREATING COMPELLING CONTENT THAT DRAWS AUDIENCES BACK TO THE CINEMAS IN 2025